all my innings up till then, I'd either nicked off or done something wrong, and just never got going.

But this day, against Pakistan, was different. It was a really good wicket and I was seeing the ball very well. Graeme Smith and I made 360-odd runs for the first wicket. And Pakistan didn't exactly have a weak bowling attack either: Mohammad Sami, Saqlain Mushtaq and a few other seamers. Their legendary quickie, Waqar Younis – though admittedly past his best – was also playing.

But, man, we were blazing hot that day. We almost reached a score of 500 on the first day. We were on about 410 when I finally went out. I think there were only 11 or 13 overs left before the close of play. So, ja, it was special.

The 1999 World Cup

Of all my performances, I'm probably the proudest of my World Cup record. And of all those innings, I reckon my best was in a Super Six game against the Aussies at Leeds during the 1999 World Cup. I played a really well-paced and composed knock – the wicket was good, and I played within myself in that innings. Nothing flashy, just percentage shots, and I went on to get 101 before Glenn McGrath bowled me.

It's funny, but when I'd woken up that morning, the first thing that popped into my mind was that I was going to score a 100. I just knew I was going to get a century. Perhaps the girl lying in bed beside me had inspired me. She worked at the hotel, where I had befriended her. I guess she was my lucky charm – she certainly was when it came to my batting. I just wish her powers had extended to my fielding and the bladdy 'dropped catch' …

For seven or eight months leading up to the tournament, I'd got into the habit of immediately throwing the ball away right after I'd caught it and got someone out. Some people thought my action was a sign of arrogance, but for me it was more about confidence … making the catch look easy. I celebrated in this way. I back myself to take every catch that comes my way, no matter how tough. And, ja, sometimes with the really easy ones I did make a bit of a meal of it, which is what I did that day. I caught the ball and quickly threw it away.

But this time, the umpires thought I hadn't had the ball under control before I tossed it and ruled it a dropped catch. But I have honestly *always* believed that I'd had the ball under control. If you watch the slo-mo replays